TRUST THAMESMEAD LIMITED

a concept in community development

REVIEW

1976 – 1984

Trust Thamesmead is a local charitable organisation established to assist in the provision of community facilities in Thamesmead.

This booklet reviews the progress of the Trust since it was formed in 1976.

INTRODUCTION

Trust Thamesmead began its life quite modestly as a convenient amalgum of a small number of community groups. As I cast my mind back to the time when I was first associated with the Trust in 1978, I recall the Arts Club, the Gymnasium, uniformed organisations, the radio station, and a number of other small groups as founder members; the needs were for charitable status for a number of the groups and for a properly-run umbrella organisation which could work with local authorities, and particularly of course with the Greater London Council in the development of the arches underneath Harrow Manorway.

Over six years things have changed very dramatically. This is not surprising, for things in Thamesmead itself have changed very dramatically and it should be expected that the work of the Trust would keep pace. It has more than kept pace.

Some of the needs remain constant. It is still an important requirement of a community organisation that it can respond in a flexible way to spontaneous needs. The Trust can do this, giving a small grant to get a group going, helping over the formation of constitutions and management committees, representing the group to other bodies outside Thamesmead until it gains confidence, even helping to mop up when a group has to come to an end.

Alongside these modest aims, which must never be neglected, the Trust has shown itself able to initiate and develop much more ambitious projects, and the monies it administers and the responsibilities it discharges are evidence enough of the confidence invested in it by the G.L.C. and a number of major funding bodies. The Swimming Pool, now entering its

final stages of planning, must come first among these achievements. The Community Workshops project, the Bridge and the Archway Project also rank high in these major undertakings.

Many of the best aspects of life in Thamesmead depend on partnership. The Trust makes some claim to giving a lead in this. The partnership between the G.L.C., Greenwich, Bexley, the I.L.E.A., local voluntary organisations, industry and commerce, the Trust's workers, and, of course, the local community of Thamesmead itself in the development of projects which make a distinct difference to the quality of life enjoyed by residents of the town is a partnership of which we are, we believe, justifiably proud, and the publication of our review makes it possible for us to pay tribute to all those partners and to look forward to the as yet unwritten chapters in the Trust's work.

K.S. Pound
Chairman

THAMESMERE POOLS

In March 1983 the Greater London Council made a grant of £1 million towards the cost of a swimming pool with a further sum of £400,000 in March 1984. This money has been invested in a special Trust Fund administered by Trust Thamesmead. In addition the G.L.C. has donated a prime site for the pool on the edge of Thamesmere Lake. The site immediately adjoins Thamesmead's proposed Central Area and the Library and Community facilities of the London Borough of Greenwich.

The London Borough of Greenwich Leisure Services Committee have also shown a determination to support the project by agreeing in principle to the management of the swimming pool for Thamesmead.

The 'Thamesmere Pools' in association with the facilities above will make a substantial contribution towards the provision of a 'heart' for the community and a meaningful Town Centre.

The following is an extract taken from the S.P.O.T (Swimming Pool on Thamesmead) Feasibility Report by its Honorary Chairman, Bill Price.

> " Building a public swimming pool in the new town centre is, we believe, a significant step towards re-affirming faith in the original concept of Thamesmead. It will also provide vital water safety training facilities at present much needed and yet little provided for in an area of canals, lakes and ponds adjacent to a major tidal river ".

The Project Development Team comprising of members from Trust Thamesmead, the London Borough of Greenwich and the Greater London Council prepared a detailed brief which makes provision for a 25 metre pool, learner pool, sun terrace and four squash courts. The project was then advertised for competition in two national journals. This advert attracted forty eight enquiries from which eleven developers were selected to prepare sketch schemes. These schemes were assessed just before Easter and four developers have now been chosen to proceed with a detailed scheme and tenders.

Final selection will be made at the end of July following full public consultation. It is proposed to start on site in November 1984 with an opening in February/March 1986.

ABOUT THE STAFF

In August 1979, the Trust appointed a full-time administrator, Mary Chambers, with voluntary community work experience in Thamesmead, her salary funded by grants from the G.L.C., Inner London Education Authority and the London Borough of Greenwich. Her principal aim to encourage and support the development of community resources through fund raising.

As administrator she has brought a lot of relevant experience to the job and has clearly indicated her commitment to work closely with local people, listening to their ideas and hopes in relation to the Trust and starting to create realistic projects on that basis. Her concern for the development of the community relations side of the Trust's work has spurred on many other people.

Various changes have taken place since 1979. Laurie Reynolds joined the Trust in March 1982 as personal assistant to the administrator. In November 1983, 'Nick' Thurston was appointed as manager of the Community Workshops with an urban aid grant sponsored by the Bexley Economic Development Unit. Both members of staff have fulfilled their tasks in a positive and cheerful spirit and we are grateful to them.

Much of the success or otherwise of any enterprise depends on the skills and personal commitment of the staff, and in the Trust we have been fortunate with our staff team. One of the most important jobs from the local community's point of view is helping the Trust become more accessible to local people.

TRUST THAMESMEAD

Thamesmead itself is a developing community and although some facilities are available there are nevertheless deficiencies that are likely to continue until Thamesmead as a whole is more fully developed. The Trust is able to bridge a gap in these deficiencies by exercising its function as a fund raising agency, also as an advice centre on how to set up projects and run them successfully, and as an adult educational resource for help with constitutions etc.

All these roles involve the Trust in responding to requests from community groups, and more positively the groups can seek out and use information to create change in the community. There will need to be more community involvement. This will come from both directions, with the providers of information attempting to bring their service to as many people as possible, and also with more active use being made of information by local self-help groups.

Where attempts have been made to make provision for leisure and recreational facilities in the community these have usually been small-scale and have often been concerned with particular issues.

The Trusts fund raising activities have to date culminated in the provision of four major capital projects for Thamesmead. The Archway Project, the Day Centre Project (The Bridge), Thamesmead Community Workshops and the Thamesmere Pools.

It is always invidious to single out particular projects from the Trust's twenty nine affiliated groups when taking into account that all are viable and give substantial benefit to the community, but the four mentioned above have brought a considerable change to the work of the Trust since 1979 and are worthy of particular mention.

THE ARCHWAY PROJECT

The Archway Project is a community intermediate treatment centre and youth project offering group work facilities with an emphasis on motor cyles.

The concept of the Archway originated in January 1980 when two groups of people carrying out similar work with young people joined forces with Trust Thamesmead to raise funds to convert an arch into a purpose-built youth centre. In order not to duplicate the facilities already provided by youth clubs in the area a motor workshop theme was adopted. The Archway now provides facilities for approximately sixty young people and has special provision for the unemployed.

Inside the Archway there are two large work spaces to either side of a central block. The space to the north is a workshop, adequate for about six motor cycles, where young people can work to gain a practical knowledge of mechanics. A second large work space to the south can either be used in conjunction with the motor workshop or for other recreational activities such as table tennis, pool etc.

The ancillary accommodation is a 'box of rooms' which require visual or audial privacy but which simultaneously serve the workshop. These facilities include a coffee bar, meeting room, toilets, and an office for the two full-time members of staff who supervise the project.

The Archway was officially opened in November 1982 and was the first major fund raising project carried out by the Trust.

THE BRIDGE

A steering group was formed in 1981, chaired by a member of the Thamesmead Christian Community and including representatives of Trust Thamesmead, FSU, Carr Gomm, and Gallions Reach Health Centre.

After various plans had been considered, the group approached the GLC for a maisonette above the shops, at 21 Tavy Bridge, which was leased to Trust Thamesmead in the Summer of 1982. The Trust also supported applications to Greenwich Council and the Tudor Trust who between them provided £10,000 for equipping and furnishing the Centre and to cover initial running costs. The Centre was to have a self-help ethos, but it required a worker to support local community groups and to invòlve other professional workers in running groups themselves. After several applications, the Trust was successful in obtaining a three-year grant from the King Edward's Hospital Fund for London of £7,500 a year to fund a part-time worker. FSU were asked to supervise the project and appointed Martin Ruddock, an experienced groupworker, to co-ordinate the activities of the Bridge, in May 1983.

By this time, several local community groups were already using the Centre regularly. A group called "Chatterbox" was set up by two local women for isolated mothers, and with some support in the early stages from FSU, has now met successfully for 18 months. Other groups, for example a group for Asian women, have met for shorter periods of time. Group members have been involved in decorating and furnishing the premises to try and provide a welcoming and informal atmosphere. A large room has been turned into an attractive creche, run by

an MSC worker. The Co-ordinator has provided support for the groups and has advised other professionals in Thamesmead on setting up groups in the Centre. There are close links with Lakeside Health Centre and the project has recently started involving a general practitioner, to run groups for parents of children with sleeping problems.

The advice and support of Trust Thamesmead, in the early days of the Bridge, helped transform the ideas of the steering group into a project that is now providing help for a wide range of Thamesmead people. It aims to help professional workers adapt their established practice for the needs of a new community, and to provide local people with the backing to establish support of their own. In a unique way, it "bridges" the gap between the helpers and the helped.

COMMUNITY WORKSHOPS

The year 1983/84 has seen the practical completion of the Community Workshops, converted from twenty nine vandalised and derelict garages in Kale Road.

Our Architects have produced a striking and effective design providing twelve workshop units of varying sizes between 250 and 600 sq.ft. with lighting and power and communal toilet and reception facilities. The conversion brought to light some structural defects in the original construction, but despite the unforseen and frustrating delays it became possible to appoint a full time manager in November 1983 and commence the interviewing and counselling of prospective tenants.

In the early stages almost all the applicants were from the Thamesmead Community and represented a wide variety of business ideas. As a result of advice and encouragement, some felt the need for more time to research and develop their ideas. Others, benefiting from detailed and sympathetic discussion of their projects, have been encouraged to set up their business closer to their markets or in more suitable premises. We wish them all the best of good fortune and are pleased to think that we may have contributed in some small way to what we hope will be eventual success in their endeavours.

Some have elected to start up with us in the Workshops and despite the difficulties of the outstanding conversion work and the consequent need sometimes to modify our plans at short notice, we now have a nucleus of four businesses installed all managed by members of the local community under the benevolent eye of the workshop manager.

With this encouraging start to the project we look forward with increasing confidence to the coming year in the knowledge that the workshops are fulfilling the need and purpose so clearly identified by Robin Auckland when the project was first initiated.

PROJECT OUTLINE

Enquiries began in the early 1970s by the Thamesmead Community Development Group, with a view to setting up a Trust as a corporate body. A Working Party was formed, with a representative of the Thamesmead Christian Community, to research and explore the possibilities, practical aims and financial prospects for a Thamesmead Trust. Initial support was, on the whole, substantial from local organisations, (such as the Thamesmead Community Association) and other interested individuals. Financial assistance for administrative costs was realised by donations from the Greater London Council and the London Borough of Bexley.

Ideally the aim was to establish a body, local to Thamesmead, and complementary to the developing authorities, able to lease or develop scarce community sites and buildings in order to enable community groups to realise their own ambitions and ideals.

In August 1976, Trust Thamesmead was officially registered as a charitable organisation with a Council of Management to decide on its policies.

The first venture of the Trust was to acquire and allocate arches under the elevated roadway in Thamesmead. The GLC have always been agreeable to lease land to an officially constituted organisation, such as Trust Thamesmead, at a favourable rent for community development.

In order to avoid unsatisfactory or unsightly use, these arches have been enclosed and used by local interest groups. This has ensured economical use

of the facilities, whilst preserving the independence of the organisations concerned. In this way, residents are involved in the thinking, planning, provision and management of their community's facilities.

Trust Thamesmead is a limited company. Its Council of Management includes representatives from the statutory bodies previously mentioned, as well as local interest groups.

The initial stated aims of the Trust were:

- assistance to developing community groups
- provision of land, property and finance
- acquisition development of sites and premises in Thamesmead
- allocation of land and buildings
- assuring that the groups take account of local needs and that they are able to be self-sufficient financially
- fund raising and seeking grant aid
- pointing out the need for community provision in Thamesmead to local authorities and other developers

The first projects to be established with the assistance of Trust Thamesmead were the Thamesmead Arts Club, the Thamesmead Gymnasium, the Y.M.C.A. Sailing Club and Insound, with the 'adoption' in 1977 from the Thamesmead Community Association, the Thamesmead Good Neighbours Scheme.

AFFILIATED GROUPS

Thamesmead Arts Club
S.P.O.T. (Swimming Pool On Thamesmead)
Thamesmead Community WOrkshops
The Archway Project
Thamesmead Day Centre - The Bridge
The Arena Project
Thamesmead Good Neighbours' Scheme
Thamesmead Amateur Boxing Club
Thamesmead Family Service Unit
Youth Concern
Heronsgate Playgroup
Lakeside Majorettes
Thamesmead Troupers
Thamesmead Gymnasium
Thamesmead Football Club
Radio Thamesmead
YMCA - Sailing Club
Community Murals
Community of Vietnam - BCRE
Thamesmead Christian Community
Thamesmead Celtic Association
Insight
Telephone Contact Group
Thamesmead Multicultural Funfield Association
Thamesmead Residents Angling Association
The Thamesmere Pools
Thamesmead Gymnastics Project
Crossways Agility Group
LINK - Gallions Reach Patients' Action Group

CONCLUSION

This review has looked back over the first eight years of the work of Trust Thamesmead. It's authors while seeking to be factual have looked at what happened, without attempting to argue the merits of the Trust's work at this stage.

There have been times of considerable difficulty. In spite of this, the early evidence is very encouraging. What this review does not and cannot show is the sheer volume of high quality work done. Amidst all the problems we have not compromised the high standards set for the Trust.

As we look forward to the future we believe there are good reasons for optimism. It is our hope that in the future we will be able to consolidate and extend the excellent work already achieved. Our programme has so far gone a long way towards justifying the optimism and enthusiasm of those of us who conceived the idea of a Thamesmead Trust and set it in motion.

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